

AUTHORING · 2026 EDITION

A Field Guide to Lattice Layouts

Every slide in this deck explains the layout it is rendered with — what it is, when to use it, and when to reach for something else

SECTION 01 · BOOKENDS AND PROSE

**The first thing to learn is which
layouts open, anchor, and close a deck.**

LAYOUT · SUBTOPIC

A subtopic slide announces a sub-section without resetting the deck.

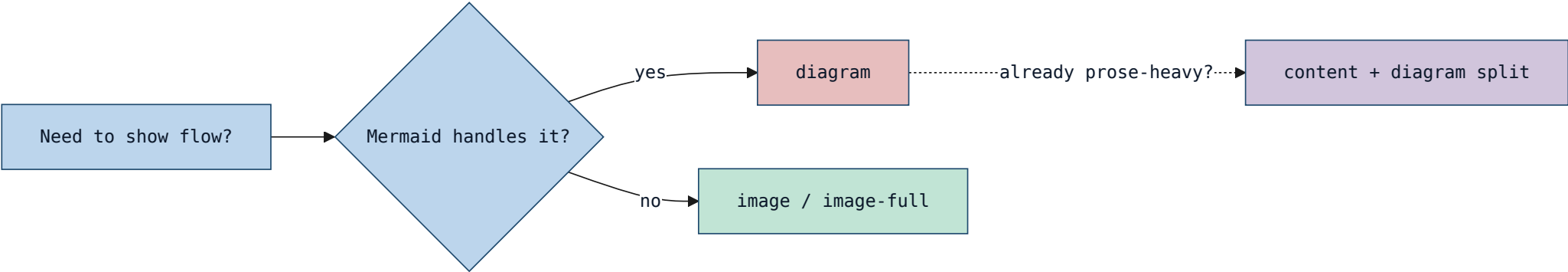
Use it mid-section to mark a new beat without the heavy chrome of a *divider*. The headline is centred, the eyebrow is short. There is room for one paragraph of context — no cards, no lists, no images.

Content is the workhorse — one heading, one paragraph, one idea.

Reach for *content* whenever you have a single claim to make and a few sentences of support. The eyebrow tag (the inline-code line above the heading) is optional but recommended for orientation. Resist adding a card grid here — if the page wants cards, switch layouts. If a slide tries to do two things, it will land as half a slide.

Diagram pairs a Mermaid block with an eyebrow caption.

Use for architecture, flow, or sequence — anything a Mermaid graph reads better than prose



LAYOUT · STATS

Stats foregrounds three or four numbers as the editorial point.

Use it when the slide's argument is the numbers themselves, not a story they support.

3-4

IDEAL COUNT

1

BIG NUMBER PER CELL

≤4

WORDS PER LABEL

0

DECORATIVE UNITS

LAYOUT · CARDS-GRID

Cards-grid is the default for four parallel ideas.

What it is

A 2×2 grid of equal-weight cards. Author with a top-level list; each item becomes a card title, each nested item becomes the body.

When to use

You have exactly 4 parallel claims that read at a similar level of generality.

When not to use

You have 3 cards (use `cards-grid three` or `cards-wide`) or 2 cards (use `compare-prose` or a 2-card cards-grid).

Composes with

`dark`, `compact`, `loose`, `mirror`, and the modifiers `three` / `four`.

[Layout](#) · [cards-grid](#) [inline code in cards](#)

Inline code chips render inside card titles and body alike.

Card title with code

v2.4

Wrap any backtick-fenced literal in card titles for inline code chips. They use the accent-soft surface so they do not fight the heading.

Body code is fine too

inline

Inline `code` inside the body uses the same chip treatment. Do not use code chips for headings — that is what the eyebrow is for.

Status-style chips

Card titles ending in a code chip read like a label + status pair. Useful for `required` / `optional` / version markers.

One chip is enough

Two chips on the same title fight each other. If you need two pieces of metadata, drop one into the body or use `list-tabular`.

Layout · cards-grid numbered, 3-card

Three numbered cards fall back to a 2-top-1-bottom arrangement.

1

Use a numbered list to get sequence

The grid recognizes ordered lists and prefixes each card with its number. Do this when the cards are sequential beats, not parallel ideas.

2

Three cards is the awkward count

2×2 grids tolerate a fourth card; with three, the layout drops the last to a wide bottom slot. Acceptable, but `cards-wide` is often cleaner.

3

Numbering is editorial, not decorative

If the order does not matter, use unordered bullets. Numbered cards say to the reader "read these in order."

Cards-stack is the right call for 2–3 substantive beats.

Use when each card carries a paragraph. Cards-grid cells get cramped when you need three or four sentences per card. Stack lets the prose breathe and keeps the eye reading top-to-bottom.

Avoid when the beats are short. If each card is a single line, stack feels sparse. Switch to `cards-grid compact` or `list` for shorter copy.

Layout · cards-grid 2 cards

Two cards in a cards-grid become a clean side-by-side.

Side-by-side, no connector

Two cards laid out horizontally with equal width. No arrow between them, no winner marker. Useful when you want a parallel read without implying causality.

Reach for instead when...

compare-prose

You want a connector arrow and a below-note. The `compare-prose` chrome reads as "two options that relate to each other"; this layout reads as "two parallel modes."

Compare-prose adds a connector arrow and an optional below-note.

OPTION A

The first card. Holds enough body text to fill comfortably. Source order is significant — the second card is what the `chosen` modifier targets.



OPTION B

The second card. The arrow between them implies direction or relationship: before / after, input / output, considered / chosen.

A trailing paragraph after the cards becomes the below-note. Use it for one explanatory sentence, never for additional argument.

“

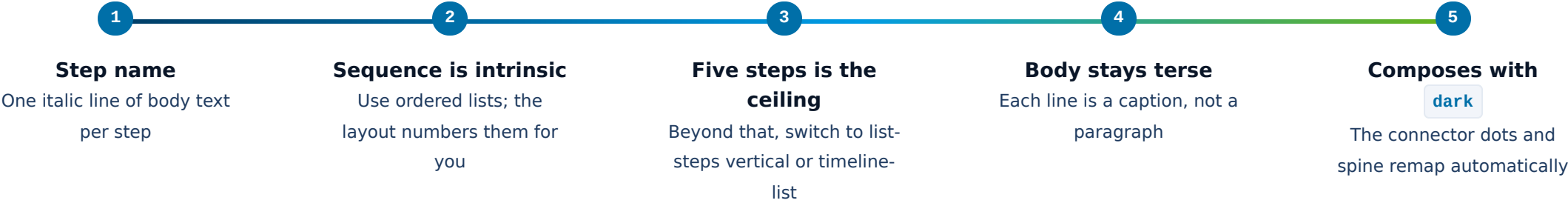
Quote layouts pull a single voice out of the deck and frame it as the editorial point — not as evidence, but as the page's argument.

”

— Use sparingly. One per section maximum.

LAYOUT · TIMELINE

Timeline lays five-or-fewer steps across the canvas horizontally.



LAYOUT · LIST

List is a stacked card list — use it for rule sets and "what it does / does not" pages.

Each top-level bullet becomes a card with an accent left-edge.

Use unordered bullets for parallel rules, numbered lists for sequenced ones.

Five to seven items is the comfortable upper bound — beyond that, split the slide.

Body text is a single line per item; if you need more, switch to `cards-stack`.

Composes cleanly with `dark`, `compact`, and `loose`.

[Layout](#) · [list](#) [numbered](#)

Numbered lists give the same layout an explicit sequence.

01 Use ordered markdown (

1. /

2.) when the order matters editorially.

02 The layout renders the number as a leading badge, not a decorative count.

03 Mix-and-match is allowed: numbered cards in one slide, bulleted in another.

04 Beyond seven items, the rhythm gets crowded — split or switch layouts.

LAYOUT · BIG-NUMBER

A large, bold, blue '1x' icon. The '1' is a simple vertical bar with a short horizontal base, and the 'x' is formed by two intersecting diagonal lines. This icon represents the 'Big-Number' layout type.

One number, one supporting paragraph. Use it when the slide's argument is a single anchor metric — a magnitude that earns its own page. Anything more than one number belongs in `stats`.



LAYOUT · SPLIT-PANEL

Split-panel · section opener with a dark accent column

Dark panel + content · split-panel

WHAT IT IS

A two-column section opener. The left column is a dark accent panel carrying the section number, an eyebrow, and the deck watermark; the right column carries a heading and a numbered list of sub-topics.

1

Use as a deep-dive opener

It reads as the start of a section that has internal structure worth previewing.

2

Three to five sub-topics

Fewer feels thin; more crowds the right column.

3

Composes with mirror

`split-panel mirror` flips the dark column to the right.

LAYOUT · CLOSING

Closing bookends the deck on a dark canvas.

*Use it for the final slide — a CTA, a working-session ask, or the next-step you want the audience to leave with.
Pagination is suppressed by convention; one closing per deck.*

VARIANT · CARDS-GRID WITH FINDING + KEY INSIGHT

A trailing blockquote becomes the slide's key insight.

What it is

The cards layout you already know, with a `>` blockquote after the cards. The blockquote renders as an accent-tinted callout below the grid.

When to use

Findings slides — the cards carry the data, the callout carries the takeaway.

Authoring rule

One blockquote, one line. Multi-line callouts crowd the grid.

Composes with

All cards-grid variants, `dark`, `compact`. The callout adapts to the canvas.

KEY INSIGHT

One trailing blockquote becomes the key insight; one trailing italic paragraph becomes a source annotation.

VARIANT · CARDS-GRID WITH INSIGHT + BELOW-NOTE

Add a plain trailing paragraph for a below-note under the insight.

The pattern

Cards followed by a `>` blockquote followed by a plain paragraph. All three render in the same slide without crowding.

The hierarchy

Cards = data. Blockquote = takeaway. Paragraph = footnote / context.

The rule

One of each, in that order. Two paragraphs after the blockquote will not stack cleanly.

The escape hatch

If you need more chrome than this, you are on the wrong layout — try `featured`.

KEY INSIGHT

The blockquote is the editorial verdict; the trailing paragraph is the small print.

The below-note sits under the insight after a hairline rule. Use it for source attribution, methodology, or one contextual sentence.

VARIANT · CARDS-GRID WITH INSIGHT + ITALIC ANNOTATION

A trailing italic-only paragraph becomes a quieter annotation.

The italic-only test

The whole paragraph wrapped in `...` markers — no surrounding regular text — triggers the annotation treatment.

It looks different from the below-note

Smaller type, italic, no rule above. Use when the line is a citation rather than a footnote.

One trick per slide

You can have an annotation OR a below-note, not both. The cascade prefers annotation when both appear.

KEY INSIGHT

The cards say what; the blockquote says so what; the annotation says where it came from.

♦ *The italic annotation reads as source attribution — quiet, citational, easy to skip.*

LAYOUT · CARDS-WIDE

Cards-wide is the right call for three sequential beats with body text.**1 Three is the sweet spot**

The layout is built for exactly three full-width cards. Each card spans the canvas horizontally and has room for two or three sentences of body text.

2 Use for "three findings", "three risks", "three failure modes"

When you need to elaborate on each beat with a paragraph, `cards-wide` gives the prose room without the cramped feel of a 3-column grid.

3 Avoid when the cards need to be parallel

If the three cards read as parallel parts of a whole, switch to `cards-grid three` for the tighter visual rhythm.

List-criteria stacks named criteria with descriptions.

01 **Speed**

The layout is for "named axis + definition" content. Each criterion gets a bold label and a one-line definition.

02 **Auditability**

Use it when the deck needs to introduce the axes that a later slide (`verdict-grid` , `compare-table`) will score against.

03 **Adoption**

Three to five criteria is comfortable. Six starts to crowd the canvas.

04 **Composes with**

`dark` , `compact` . Avoid pairing with `loose` — list-criteria already carries vertical rhythm.

Verdict-grid scores 4 options against 4 criteria with checkboxes.

Option A · Skipped

Pass marker

Partial marker

Pass marker

Fail marker

Description text below the verdicts. Three to four lines is the comfortable cap per cell.

Option B · Partial

Fail marker

Pass marker

Pass marker

Fail marker

Use the `[x]` / `[ ]` / `[-]` GitHub-flavored task markers — the layout converts them into pass/fail/partial pills.

Option C · Risky

Pass marker

Pass marker

Partial marker

Fail marker

Authoring tip: keep the criterion names in the same order across all four cards, or the visual reading breaks down.

Option D · Recommended



Pass marker

Pass marker

Pass marker

Pass marker

The all-pass card is the editorial verdict. There is no built-in "winner" badge — make it land through copy.

LAYOUT · COMPARE-TABLE

Compare-table renders a markdown table with chrome that reads at projector range.

WHEN TO USE	USE COMPARE-TABLE	USE VERDICT-GRID
Many criteria	✓	✗
Many options	✓	Caps at 4
Per-cell prose	✗	✓
Heavy chrome	✗ (typography-only)	✓ (cards + pills)
Reading rhythm	Scan vertically	Scan horizontally

♦ The same data fits both — pick the form that matches how the audience will read it.

Glossary

A - S

TERM	DEFINITION
Annotation	A trailing italic-only paragraph on a card-bearing slide. Renders smaller and quieter than a below-note.
Below-note	A trailing plain paragraph on a card-bearing slide. Sits under a hairline rule; carries one contextual sentence.
Card	The accent-edged content unit used by <code>cards-grid</code> , <code>cards-stack</code> , <code>cards-wide</code> , <code>featured</code> , and several other layouts.
Eyebrow	The short inline-code line above a slide heading. Renders in the accent colour at small caps weight.
Insight	A trailing blockquote on a card-bearing slide. Renders as an accent-tinted callout below the cards.
Modifier	A class added alongside the layout class — <code>dark</code> , <code>compact</code> , <code>loose</code> , <code>mirror</code> , <code>numbered</code> , <code>accent</code> . Composable in most cases.
Slot	A named region of a layout — title, header, footer, eyebrow, watermark, content area. Most layouts pre-reserve their slots.

Glossary

TERM	DEFINITION
Spectrum stripe	The default top border on light slides — a multi-stop gradient. The <code>accent</code> modifier replaces it with one solid colour.
Status pill	A trailing inline-code chip on a card title that the layout reads as a status label (<code>on-track</code> , <code>at-risk</code> , etc.). Used by <code>progress</code> and <code>timeline-list</code> .
Watermark	The deck-name string anchored to the bottom edge of <code>divider</code> , <code>subtopic</code> , <code>closing</code> , and <code>split-panel</code> slides. Reads from frontmatter.
Connector	The arrow rendered between two cards in <code>compare-prose</code> , <code>before-after</code> , and <code>decision</code> . Vertical or horizontal depending on layout.
Below-note	See above. Listed twice because it earns its weight in authoring practice.
Pillage	Not a real term. The glossary auto-paginates the entries; you can split a glossary across two slides without losing rhythm.

LAYOUT · FEATURED

Featured is one hero card plus two supporting cards.

The hero card · the one editorial point



The first card in the markdown becomes the hero. It carries the accent-tinted background and the editorial weight. Use it for the slide's central claim.

First supporting card

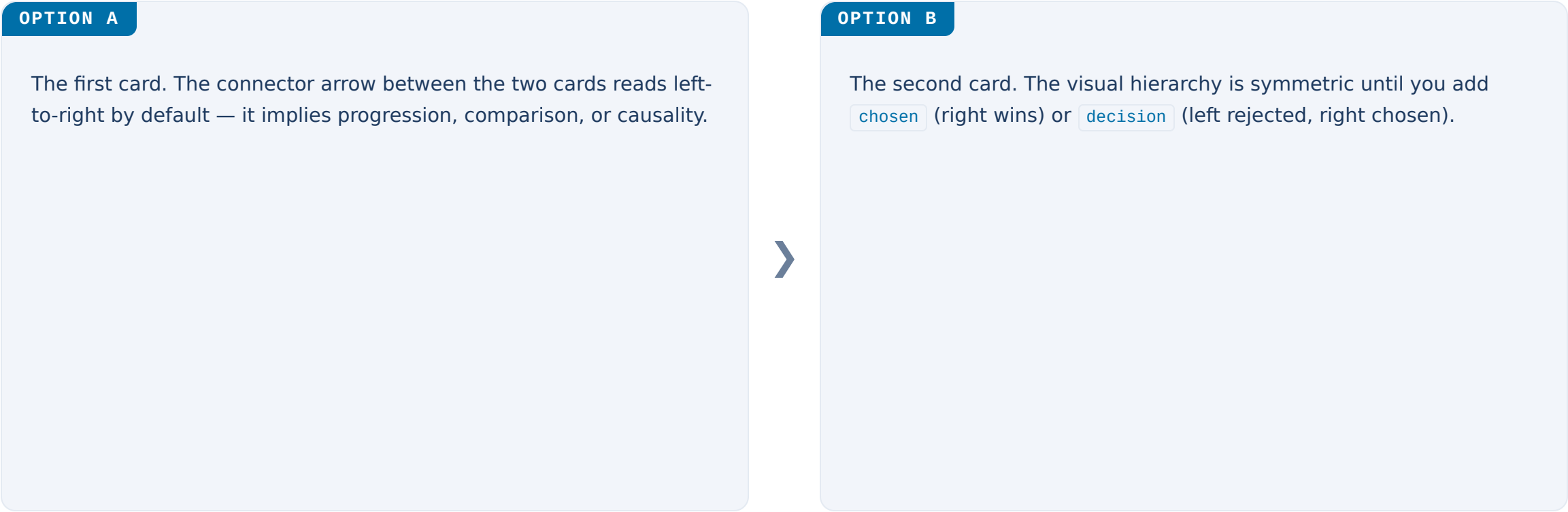
Subsequent cards stack to the right. They support, qualify, or extend the hero claim. Two supporting cards is the sweet spot — three crowds the column.

Second supporting card

Composition tip: pair `featured mirror` with a deck that reads right-to-left, or when the hero claim should land last in the audience scan.

Layout · compare-prose with below-note

Two cards, one connector, one explanatory note below.



The trailing paragraph is the below-note: one explanatory sentence under a hairline rule. Reach for it when the comparison needs context the cards cannot carry.

List-steps is a horizontal sequence with a connector spine.

STEP 01

Three to four steps

Five fits but starts to feel cramped. Beyond five, switch to `list-steps vertical` or `timeline-list`.

STEP 02

The connector is editorial

Each step connects to the next with an arrow — the layout reads as a process, not a parallel set.

STEP 03

Composes with phase / milestone

`phase` renames the prefix STEP → PHASE. `milestone` renames it to MILESTONE. `lettered` swaps numbers for letters.

STEP 04

Composes with vertical

`list-steps vertical` stacks the steps as rows; useful when each step needs more body text than a horizontal row can hold.

List-tabular adds a metadata column to each list item.

01	The pattern	Each item has three lines: title, body, italic-meta	AUTHORING · 3-LINE ITEM
02	Use for definition + meta	Glossary-like content where each term carries a unit, source, or category	REACH · KEEP META SHORT
03	The italic third line	Wrap the third line in <code>...</code> to flag it as the meta column	CONVENTION · ITALIC = META
04	Six items is comfortable	Eight crowds the canvas; if you need more, split or switch to <code>glossary</code>	CAPACITY · ~6 ROWS

Header stays uppercase — footer renders as written.

Set `header:` and `footer:` in deck frontmatter for default chrome on every slide. Override per-slide with ``` and `directives`. The header always uppercases via CSS `text-transform`; the footer renders exactly as authored, so reach for sentence case there. The `_paginate: false` directive suppresses pagination on a single slide – used here on `title` and `closing``.

LAYOUT · CODE

Code reserves the slide for a single fenced code block.

AUTHORING RULE · ONE BLOCK PER SLIDE

```
// Use the `code` layout when one snippet  
// IS the slide. The layout sets a max  
// width, generous padding, and locks  
// the eyebrow above the block.  
  
const layout = "code";  
const blocks = 1;           // exactly one  
const supportsLanguages = "every Marp-supported lang";  
  
// For two blocks (before/after, A/B),  
// switch to `compare-code`.
```

Compare-code shows two snippets side-by-side with eyebrows above each.

```
# Two code blocks with no chrome.  
# Reader has to figure out which  
# is which.  
def before(x):  
    return x * 2
```

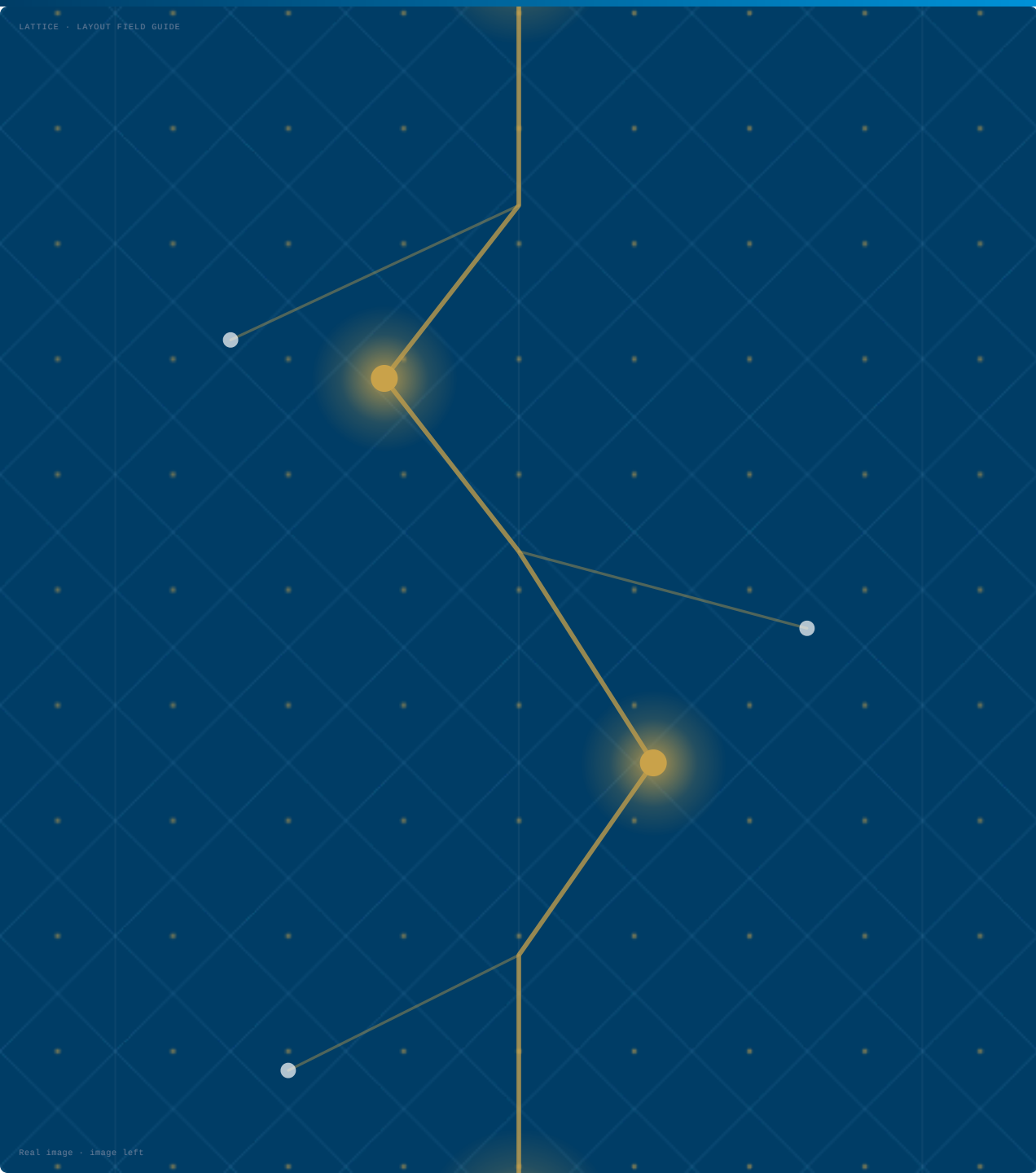
```
# Eyebrows above each block label  
# them. The connector between the  
# blocks implies progression.  
def after(x):  
    return x * 2 # but explained
```

LAYOUT · IMAGE

Image is half-canvas image right, half-canvas text left.

The default places the image in the right slot and the text in the left. Drop the asset in with the standard Marp *bg right fit* directive — Lattice respects native aspect ratios and fills any remaining bands with the lattice pattern. Authors should expect to see the image they dropped in, not a cropped variant.

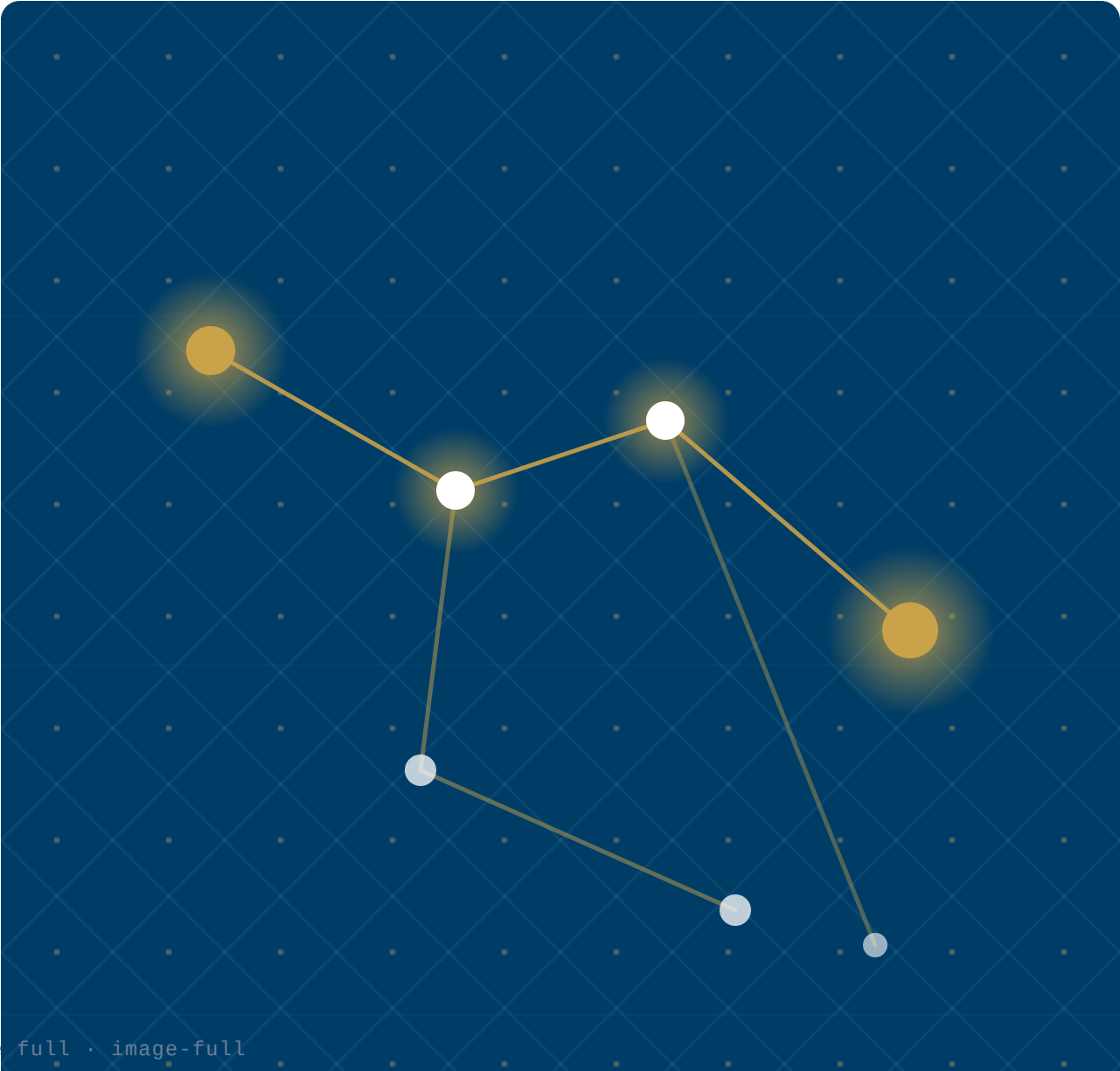




LAYOUT · IMAGE LEFT

Image left flips the orientation — image left, text right.

Use `image left` (or the cross-cutting `image mirror` modifier) when you want the image to land first in the audience's reading order. Common case: portrait assets that read better as a leading visual than as a trailing one. The text padding swaps to match.



MODIFIER · DARK

The dark modifier inverts the canvas without changing the layout.

Add *dark* alongside any layout class — palette remaps automatically through CSS variables

Modifier · dark on content

Dark is a palette swap, not a different layout.

Every colour in the system references CSS custom properties — `--bg`, `--text-heading`, `--text-body`, `--border`, `--accent-soft`. The `dark` class remaps those properties on the slide root; the layout's geometry and spacing are unchanged. The spectrum top stripe is suppressed on dark slides; the `accent` modifier restores a solid accent stripe in its place.

Modifier · dark on list

The card stack renders cleanly on dark backgrounds.

Card fills shift to `--bg-alt` (a dark grey-blue), borders shift to `--border-dark`.

The accent left edge keeps the same hue — `--accent` is canvas-neutral by design.

Body text shifts to `--text-body` (a warm light tone, never pure white).

All inline code chips remap to a darker `--accent-soft` while keeping AA contrast.

No layout-specific overrides are needed — every layout that uses these tokens dark-renders for free.

Modifier · dark on cards-stack

Two-card layouts work equally well inverted to dark.

The discipline of dark mode is to **change nothing structural**. Same heading, same eyebrow, same card geometry, same spacing. Only the palette tokens move. If a slide reads well on light and badly on dark (or vice versa), the cause is content density, not the modifier.

Reach for `dark` when a slide carries editorial weight — section breaks, declarative principles, the closing line of an argument. Reach for it sparingly. A deck that is half dark and half light is harder to read than one that uses dark as punctuation.

Phase renames the prefix word from STEP to PHASE.

PHASE 01

The change is purely textual

The layout still renders identical chrome — connector spine, numbered badges, vertical rhythm. Only the prefix label moves from STEP 01 to PHASE 01.

PHASE 02

Use phase for plans that span weeks-to-quarters

"Step" reads as a 5-minute unit; "Phase" reads as a 5-week unit. Match the prefix to the timescale you are describing.

PHASE 03

Sibling modifiers

`milestone` renames to MILESTONE;
`lettered` swaps numbers for letters; they all compose with `vertical`, `dark`, and `compact`.

Modifiers compose: milestone renames the word, lettered swaps the format.

MILESTONE A

Two modifiers, one slide

`milestone` changes the prefix word to MILESTONE; `lettered` swaps numeric badges for alphabetic ones (A / B / C). Both at once gives you "MILESTONE A · MILESTONE B · MILESTONE C".

MILESTONE B

Read order is unchanged

Letters do not imply a different ordering than numbers. They are a typographic choice, not an editorial one.

MILESTONE C

Use lettered when the audience confuses sequence with magnitude

"Phase 3" can sound bigger than "Phase 1"; "Phase C" carries no such weight. Useful for parallel workstreams.

Vertical stacks the steps as rows; the connector becomes a down-arrow.

STEP 01

Use when each step needs body text

Horizontal steps cap each row at one short caption. Vertical lets you write a full sentence per step without truncating.



STEP 02

Composes with compact

`list-steps vertical compact` shrinks the spacing between rows so all four steps fit on one slide. Without `compact`, three rows is the comfortable cap.



STEP 03

The connector flips

The arrow rendered between steps rotates from horizontal to a vertical down-arrow. No authoring change required.

Chosen flags the right-hand card as the winner.

CONSIDERED ALTERNATIVE

Source order matters: the *first* card in the markdown is always the considered alternative; the *second* is the one `chosen` flags.



THE CHOSEN PATH

The right card carries an accent left-edge and an accent-tinted background — same visual contract as a featured card. The connector arrow remains, now reading as "we chose this one."

The right card carries an accent left-edge and accent-tinted background — the same visual contract used by featured cards.

Decision composes chosen + rejected with a labelled connector.

THE REJECTED OPTION

The left card is rendered with strikethrough type and a muted accent — visually struck off the page. It still occupies its column, so the reader can see what was considered before being dropped.



THE CHOSEN OPTION

The right card carries the same accent treatment as `chosen` alone. The connector between them is amplified with a labelled DECISION pill so the slide reads as a recorded judgement.

The left card is struck through to read as the option considered then dropped; the right card carries the chosen visual; the connector is amplified and labelled DECISION.

Vertical stacks the two cards; the arrow connector rotates 90°.

CARD A — TOP

The first card now occupies the top half of the canvas. Use vertical when the comparison is before/after in time, where reading top-to-bottom matches the editorial flow.



CARD B — BOTTOM

The second card sits below. The connector arrow rotates from horizontal to a down-arrow without authoring intervention.

MODIFIER · CARDS-GRID THREE

Three switches the grid from 2 columns to 3 columns.

When to use

Three parallel concepts of equal weight.
Without `three`, three cards fall back to a 2-top-1-bottom layout, which reads as "two main, one trailing."

Card body length

Three columns leaves less width per card.
Keep body text to one short sentence, or pair with `compact` for tighter padding.

Composes with

`dark`, `compact`, `loose`, `mirror`. Avoid pairing with `four` (the modifiers conflict).

MODIFIER · CARDS-GRID FOUR

Four switches to 4 columns; pair with compact for visual balance.

Four columns

The grid switches from a 2×2 to a 1×4 — all four cards in a single row.

Use for short labels

With four columns, each card has narrow width. Restrict body text to one short line per card.

Pair with compact

`cards-grid four compact` shrinks the column gaps and card padding so the row reads as a unit, not four cramped boxes.

Avoid for prose-heavy content

If any card needs more than a single sentence, switch back to `cards-grid` (2×2) or `cards-wide` (3-row).

Horizontal flips cards-stack from a vertical stack to a row.

1

Three short beats. Use when each beat is a sentence or two and you want them to read as "one argument in three moves."

2

Bold-led copy. The convention is to lead each card with a bolded label (Claim. / Evidence. / Implication.) and let the rest of the sentence follow.

3

Avoid for prose. With three columns of stacked content, body text gets cramped. If you need paragraphs, switch back to vertical `cards-stack`.

MODIFIER · IMAGE MIRROR

Mirror flips the image to the other half — alias of legacy `image left`.

The half-canvas image moves from the right slot to the left slot, and the text padding swaps to match. `mirror` is the cross-cutting orientation flag — the same modifier flips `featured`, `split-panel`, and `compare-prose`. The legacy `image left` class is preserved as an alias for one release; new authoring should prefer `image mirror`.

MODIFIER · FEATURED MIRROR

Mirror puts the hero card on the right; sub-cards stack on the left.

First supporting card on the left

Useful when the rest of the deck reads right-to-left or when the editorial weight needs to land on the right edge as the next slide opens.

Second supporting card below

Identical structure, identical authoring; only the visual side changes.

The hero now reads from the right



The featured layout normally leads with the accented hero card on the left and stacks supporting cards on the right. Mirror swaps the columns without touching the markdown contract.

WHAT CHANGES — AND WHAT DOESN'T

The watermark, eyebrow, and section number stay anchored to the panel's own box. Only the column position flips. The numbered list of sub-topics moves to the left column.

1

The accent panel and its content travel together.

The panel is a structural slot, not a styling treatment.

2

The reading order changes for left-to-right audiences.

Reach for mirror when the next slide opens with content on the right.

3

The modifier composes with dark.

`split-panel mirror dark` is fully supported.

S

MODIFIER · SPLIT-PANEL MIRROR

Split-panel mirror moves the dark accent panel to the right.

Mirror composes with chosen — the accented card reads from the left.

THE CHOICE

Mirror only flips the rendering. The chosen card now appears on the left visually, but the editorial intent (left = considered, right = chosen) is preserved by reading order alone.

CONSIDERED ALTERNATIVE

Source order does not change with mirror. The first card in the markdown is still the considered alternative; the second is still the one `chosen` flags.



The below-note still appears under both cards after the hairline rule.

MODIFIER · DIVIDER NUMBERED

Numbered stamps an auto-counter in the top-right corner.

The CSS counter walks the whole deck once and increments on every *divider.numbered* slide. Authors do not number sections by hand — the layout does it. If you re-order or insert a section, the counter recomputes automatically. There is no markdown to maintain.

MODIFIER · SUBTOPIC NUMBERED

Each bookend layout owns its own counter.

The subtopic counter is independent of the divider counter. A mid-deck subtopic stamps `01` even when the dividers are already at `04`.

This separation lets you have multiple counted streams running in parallel — major sections via `divider numbered`, minor sub-topics via `subtopic numbered`, closing parts via `closing numbered`.

MODIFIER · CLOSING NUMBERED

The closing series gets its own auto-stamp too.

Use it for multi-part decks where the closing slide of each part should carry the part number. Single-deck closings rarely need numbering — reach for plain closing instead.

LAYOUT · MATRIX-2X2

Matrix-2x2 sorts items into a four-quadrant grid.

TWO AXES · FOUR QUADRANTS

High Y / Low X

Quadrant content goes here. Each item is a bulleted list under the quadrant label.

Multiple items per quadrant are supported.

High Y / High X

Use when the question is "where on these two axes?" — vendor sorting, risk-vs-reward, urgent-vs-important.

Low Y / Low X

Quadrants accept short prose; long prose belongs in `cards-grid`.

Low Y / High X

Empty quadrants are part of the signal — author them with an italic note.

LAYOUT · DECISION

Decision is one chosen card plus two rejection-rationale cards.

*USE IT FOR COMMITTED-DECISION SLIDES***THE CHOICE**

One short card naming what was decided.
Lead with the verb: "Build", "Defer",
"Adopt".

WHY NOT THE ALTERNATIVE

One short card naming the rejected option
and the reason. Reach for one or two —
never more than three.

WHY NOT DELAY

A second rejection card. Common pattern:
alternative + delay. The slide reads as "what
we are doing, what we are not, why now."

LAYOUT · BEFORE-AFTER

Before-after is two cards labelled by time, with a connector and below-note.

TIME-SHAPED COMPARISON

BEFORE

The first card holds the prior state. Body text describes how things were — process, performance, posture.

**AFTER**

The second card holds the new state. Body text describes what changed and what the change yields.

♦ The below-note explains what *caused* the shift. Use it to credit the architectural change rather than the metric — "the cause was X, not a Y optimisation."

MODIFIER · BANNER-TAG

Banner-tag changes the chrome — same content, different framing.

SAME DECISION · DIFFERENT VISUAL EMPHASIS

THE CHOICE

The `banner-tag` modifier replaces the eyebrow with a full-width banner across the top of the slide. Reach for it when the decision is the slide's headline.

WHY NOT THE ALTERNATIVE

The body cards are unchanged. Same source markdown, different chrome.

WHY NOT DELAY

Composes with `dark` and `accent`. Avoid pairing with `mirror` — banner is visually anchored top-left.

Modifier · banner-tag on before-after

Banner-tag also fronts the before-after layout.

TIME-SHAPED COMPARISON · BANNER EMPHASIS



Principles is a tight numbered list of declarative beliefs.

01 The list is the slide — no body text, no cards, no chrome.

02 Three or four lines is the comfortable cap; five starts to crowd.

03 Lead with "We" or with an imperative — principles are stated, not described.

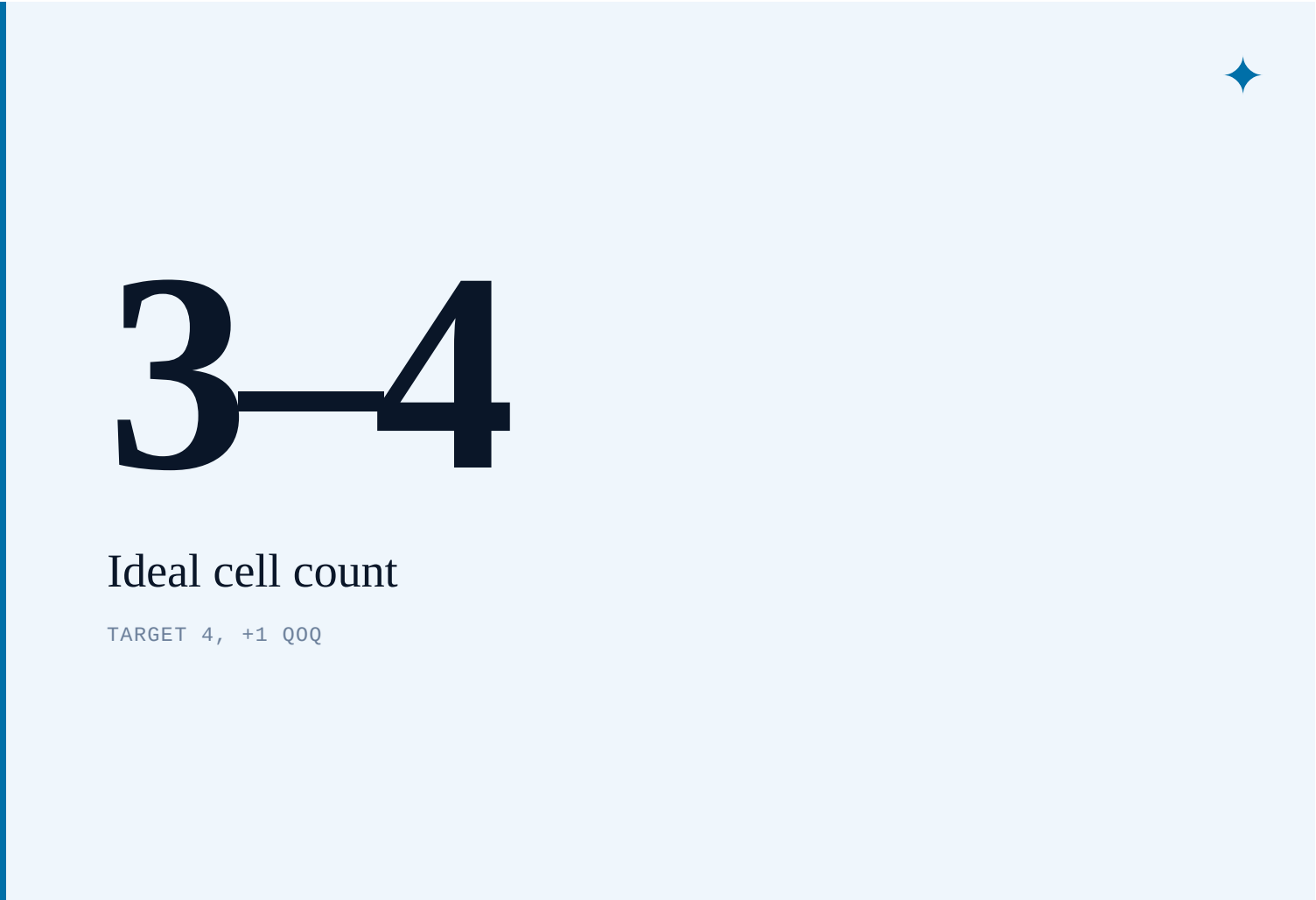
LAYOUT · ROADMAP

Roadmap is a **workstream × phase grid built from a markdown table.**

AUTHORING	PHASE 01	PHASE 02	PHASE 03
Workstream	The leftmost column	is the sticky label	—
Phase row	Each row is a	workstream's	trajectory
Empty cell	Render as	a thin	dash
Pill style	Phase columns	carry numbered chrome	—

The first column is the sticky workstream label; phase columns carry numbered chrome; empty cells render as a thin dash.

Kpi shows 3-4 metrics with target and delta lines.



3-4

Ideal cell count

TARGET 4, +1 QOQ

3-line

Cell anatomy: number, label,
target/delta

TARGET 3, FLAT

target

Modifier — adds the target/delta footer

TARGET ON, NO CHANGE

target QoQ

The italic delta line is auto-styled

TARGET QOQ, +0.4× QOQ

Layout · agenda progress-2 modifier

Agenda lists the sections of the deck with optional progress chrome.

01 Section name — page number

02 The progress-2 modifier highlights the second item

03 Use it as the second slide so audiences know the structure

04 Composes with progress-3, progress-4, etc — the digit is the highlighted index

05 Authoring rule — keep entries to one short line each

LAYOUT · ACTORS

Actors is a RACI-style ownership grid — role title + body.

Bolded label

code-chip role

Each actor has a bold heading, an inline-code role pill, and a body paragraph.

Use for ownership clarity

responsible party

Reach for actors when the slide answers "who does what" — RACI, lifecycle ownership, decision rights.

Three to four roles

comfortable cap

More than four crowds the column rhythm. If you need five, split the slide.

Composes with dark

compact too

Both modifiers compose cleanly. `accent` is also supported.

LAYOUT · TLDR NUMBERED

Tldr is a recap list with optional slide cross-references.

01 One bullet per takeaway. → cap at five.

02 Trailing arrow + slide number gives the deep-dive pointer. → optional.

03 The numbered modifier auto-stamps the slide. → counter is shared with
`divider numbered` .

04 Reach for tldr after a long section. → the audience will thank you.

05 Avoid tldr at deck open. → use agenda instead.

LAYOUT · CHECKLIST

Checklist renders GitHub-flavored task markers as state pills.

What this layout knows about state.

● Use

[x]

 for shipped / done / pass items

● Use

[-]

 for in-progress / partial items

with optional pill

● In-progress items render with a striped fill

○ Use

[]

 for not-yet / future items

Phase 2

○ Empty checkboxes render with a quiet outline

MODIFIER · COMPACT

Compact tightens the spacing scale ~25%, end-to-end.

What changes

`--sp-xs` through `--sp-2xl` shrink. Card gaps, list gutters, and section padding follow because every layout reads them via `var()`.

What does not change

Type ramp, palette, and chrome reservation (header / footer / pagination) are untouched. Compact is a density flag, not a different layout.

When to reach for it

You have one more card than fits, or your prose runs the section by 1–2 lines, or you want a denser visual rhythm without rewriting copy.

Composition

`compact` composes with `dark`, `accent`, and any layout where density makes sense. It is silently incompatible with `title`, `divider`, and `image-full`.

MODIFIER · LOOSE

Loose is the inverse — more breathing room, same layout machinery.

The spacing scale grows ~25% rather than shrinks. Sections that already look generous become luxurious; sections that look cramped become balanced. Reach for *loose* when the slide carries a single editorial point and you want the page to feel deliberately quiet — values pages, declarative principles, the closing line of an argument.

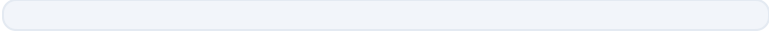
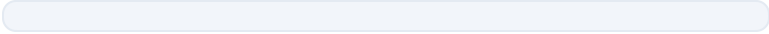
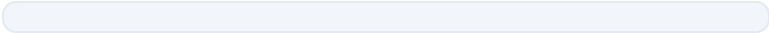
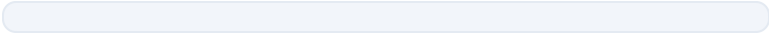
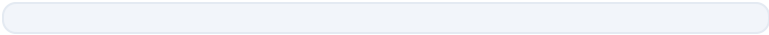
The discipline is the same as `compact` from the other side: do not change the type ramp, do not change the chrome, do not change the layout. Only the variables that govern between-element rhythm move.

KEY INSIGHT

Density is not the same as importance. `loose` says: this page deserves room — not because it carries more, but because it carries one thing well.

Progress renders horizontal bars with percentage labels and status pills.

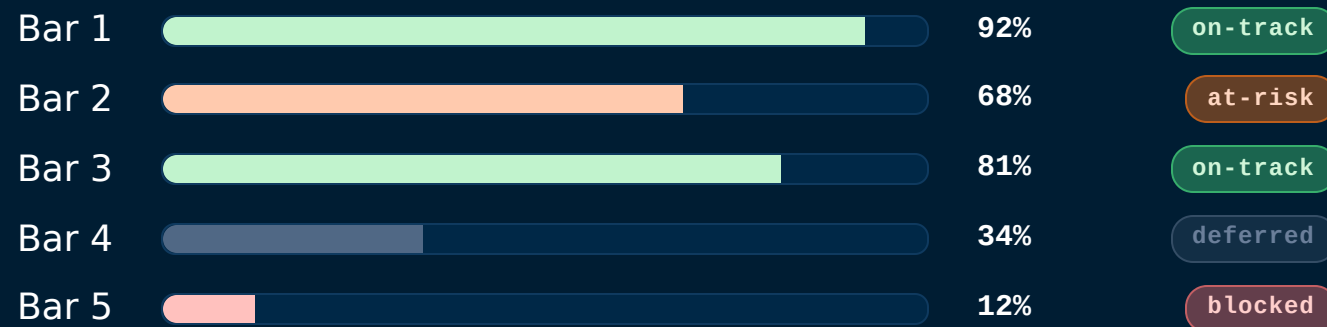
Snapshot taken at 14:00 UTC. Status pills tint the bar fill; the lucent strip lifts the chart from the canvas.

Use trailing <code>\ pct%\` for the bar fill` on-track`</code>		
Use a second trailing pill for status		at- risk
Five rows is the comfortable cap		deferred
Composes with dark and minimal modifiers		blocked
Authoring is just a top- level list		done

Source attribution lives in a trailing italic line.

Same data, dark canvas — status colours hold their contrast.

The status pills carry their own contrast logic; on the dark canvas they shift to slightly lifted variants of the same hues. The lucent strip darkens proportionally so the chart still reads as a separate plane from the canvas.



Timeline-list is a vertical timeline with date pills and trailing status.

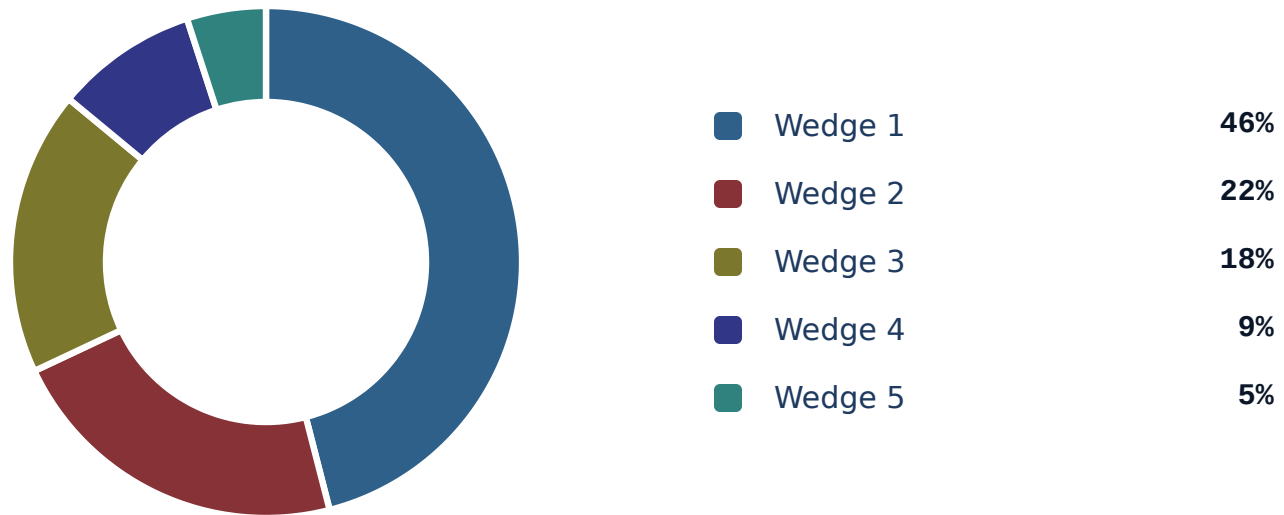
Use it when the timeline has more than five items, or when each milestone needs a date and a status. The spine and dots come for free; date pills lead each item, status pills trail.



Source attribution lives in a trailing italic line.

Piechart renders an SVG donut with an author-ordered legend.

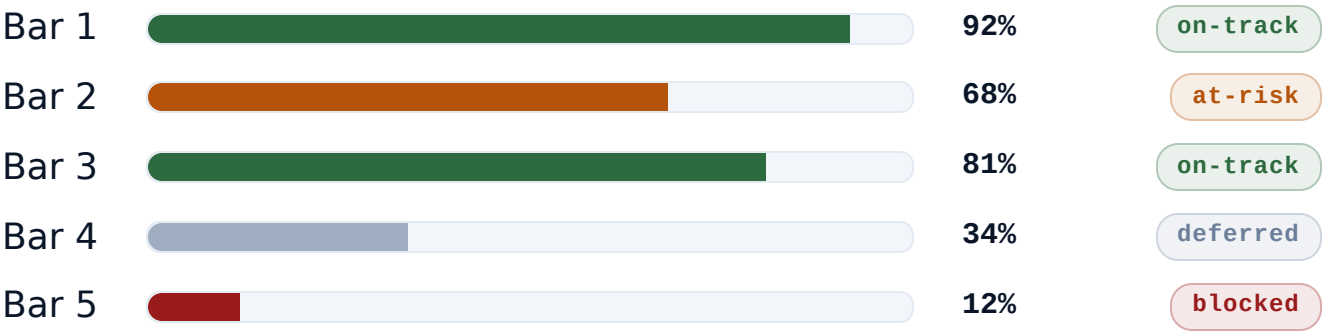
Wedges drawn proportionally to the percentages in the source list. The legend reads in author order with raw values; the donut reads as a single visual unit.



Refreshed weekly · last updated 2026-05-07

Minimal strips the lucent strip and lets the chart dominate.

The lucent strip is gone; the header reads as quiet typography with an accent hairline, and the chart consumes the page. Reach for minimal when the chart IS the slide — no surrounding argument, no supporting prose, just the data.



Source: Linear · refreshed 2026-05-07

MODIFIER · ACCENT

Accent replaces the rainbow stripe with a single editorial colour.

The default top border is a spectrum gradient — a system signal that the page is part of a wider deck. The accent modifier swaps that stripe for one solid colour and tints the slide heading. Use it when one slide carries the editorial weight of a section and you want the visual chrome to say so.

It composes with `dark`: on the dark canvas the spectrum top-stripe is suppressed entirely, so `accent.dark` restores a solid accent stripe in its place — preserving the visual signal across both canvases.